Module 1: Fundamentals of Product Management

Detailed supplement: the deck topics that extend the handbook module, with examples, exercises and a quiz

Written by Varun Kumar, for SkillNavora · Draft

Official site: www.skillnavora.in

Prepared for Skillnavora — Learn. Practise. Implement. Grow.

MODULE 1 · HOW TO USE THIS SUPPLEMENT

Coverage map: what is new and what is already in the module

Read this supplement next to the main Module 1 handbook. Topics marked **Extended** already have a section in the handbook; this PDF adds the examples and exercises. Topics marked **New** were not in the handbook.

Topic	Handbook section	Status here
What is a product	1.2	Extended: food-delivery value chain and a fintech example
What is product management	1.3	Extended: value for users and for the business
B2B vs B2C	1.17	Extended: two worked company examples only (table already in handbook)
Day in the life of a PM	1.3 (partial)	New: five-part daily routine
Stakeholder map	1.14	New: who the PM orchestrates, and what each team owns
Skills a PM needs	—	New: seven skill areas
AI-first product management	—	New: definition and use (the stack diagram was image-only, see note)
Product thinking and framework	1.15	New: four questions, problem space and solution space
Good vs mediocre products	1.15	New: side-by-side table
Six habits to build product sense	1.15	Extended: six practices with a weekly routine
Three product thinking traps	—	New: solution-first, building for everyone, wrong timing
Problem statement formula	—	New: [user] needs [outcome] because [insight]
Breakout exercise: Bistro by Blinkit	—	New: repeat-usage problem, step by step
Take-home: Nykaa journey and user chats	—	New: assignment with a checklist

NOTE ON THE SOURCE

Two slides in the source material were pictures with no readable text: the AI product stack diagram and one framework chart. They are not described here. The framework itself is taught from its text labels, which were readable. Hypothetical examples are labelled.

EXTENDED · SECTION 1.2

What is a product?

A product solves a specific problem or need for a defined group of users, and it delivers that value in a repeatable way. The handbook's three parts still apply: value, experience and business model.

Worked example: a food-delivery company

A food order passes through several steps. Each step is a product decision, and each one can have its own app or screen:

1. The customer orders food from the customer app.
2. The restaurant receives the order in its restaurant app.
3. A delivery executive receives the order in the delivery app.
4. The restaurant prepares and packs the food.
5. The delivery executive travels to the restaurant and picks up the order, helped by driver tracking.
6. The food is delivered to the customer.

The deck shows that one order touches at least three apps and one tracking service. A PM for this company must decide which step matters most to the user, not only which app is easiest to build.

Example (illustrative)	Problem the user had	Solution the product gave
PhonePe (B2C, digital payments)	People needed a fast, cashless way to pay.	UPI-based transactions made digital payments seamless.

LEVEL 1 · BEGINNER

Ask the three questions for any product you use: What job does it do for me? How does it feel to use? How does the company earn money from it?

EXTENDED · SECTION 1.3

What is product management?

In simple terms, product management is about creating value for users and capturing value for the business. Both halves matter. A product that users love but that loses money will not last, and a product that makes money but that users dislike will not keep its customers.

Company (illustrative)	Value for users	Value for the business
Swiggy or Zomato (B2C, food delivery)	Fast, convenient food from restaurants nearby.	Commission from restaurants and fees from users.
Slack (B2B, SaaS)	Teams talk efficiently without email overload.	Subscription revenue from companies.

These examples come from the source deck. They illustrate the idea; they are not reports of real company results.

NEW · DAY IN THE LIFE

What a PM does day to day

A PM's job is not only to write PRDs or attend meetings. It is to move the product forward by creating clarity across teams. A typical PM day contains five kinds of work:

Activity	What it looks like	Output
1. User input	Talk to users, read feedback, spot friction.	A list of real pain points
2. Problem clarity	Decide what matters now and what can wait.	A short problem statement
3. Team alignment	Work with design, engineering and the business.	Shared understanding of scope
4. Decision making	Review trade-offs, scope and priorities.	A decision that is written down
5. Measurement	Check metrics and decide what to improve next.	The next experiment or change

PMs sit between users' needs, the business's goals and what the team can build. That is why the job is about orchestration more than control.

PRACTICE

Keep a log for three working days. Tag each task with one of the five activities. Which activity took most of your time? Which one did you skip?

NEW · STAKEHOLDER MAP

Who the PM orchestrates

PMs do not build alone. The deck's stakeholder map shows what each group brings and what the PM must keep aligned:

Group	What they own	What the PM needs from them
Engineering	Feasibility and estimates	Honest effort ranges and technical risks
Design	UX quality and user flows	Clear problems, time to test ideas
Sales and business	Revenue and commitments	Customer objections and deal timing
Marketing	Positioning and launch	Who the product is for and why it wins
Leadership	Vision and resources	Priorities, trade-offs and decisions
Users	Voice, needs and feedback	Real evidence, not personas alone
Roadmap	Single source of truth	Agreed scope that everyone can see

The PM is the orchestrator: the one person who keeps these views consistent.

NEW · SKILLS

Skills a PM needs

The deck lists seven skill areas. You do not need to be an expert in all of them on day one, but you should know which one is your weakest.

- **Technology:** enough to ask good questions about how a system works.
- **Product thinking:** framing problems before choosing solutions.
- **Communication:** writing and speaking clearly to different groups.
- **Execution:** turning decisions into shipped work on time.
- **Data and metrics:** choosing measures that show whether users benefit.
- **Business acumen:** understanding revenue, cost and risk.
- **Leadership and collaboration:** aligning people who do not report to you.

NEW · AI-FIRST PRODUCT MANAGEMENT

Using AI as a PM tool

AI-first product management means using AI as a tool at every stage of building a product: understanding user needs, building features and helping the product grow. It means finding better ideas and making more confident decisions. It does not replace product thinking. AI helps you move faster and go deeper.

Where AI helps a PM

- Faster research: summarising interviews, reviews and support tickets.
- Better drafts: first versions of problem statements, PRDs and test plans.
- Deeper analysis: spotting patterns in usage data, then checking them.
- Quicker prototypes: testing an idea before the team commits.

WATCH OUT

AI speeds up execution, and it cannot replace clear thinking or user understanding. Always check AI output against real users and real data. Do not let a fluent answer stand in for evidence.

EXTENDED · SECTION 1.15

Product thinking and product sense

Product thinking is the skill of knowing what makes a product useful, and loved, by people. The deck quotes Julie Zhuo, former VP of Design at Facebook, for this idea. Product thinking is the first step in building a product. It means spending more time on the problem space than on the solution space.

Four questions to ask before you build

1. Who is this for?
2. What problem are we solving?
3. Why does this problem matter now?
4. How do we know this is the right solution?

The product thinking framework

The framework has two halves. The problem space comes first.

Space	Question	What it means
Problem space	Goal: what is the objective?	The outcome you want, in plain words
Problem space	User persona: who are my users?	A defined segment, not 'everyone'
Problem space	User journey: what is their current experience?	Each step, with friction marked
Problem space	Problem identification: what pain or unmet need exists?	The specific problem with evidence
Problem space	Prioritisation: which problem should we solve first?	The ranking, with a reason
Solution space	Solutioning: what is the best solution for the prioritised problem?	One or two candidate solutions
Solution space	Measurement and iteration: what are the success metrics, and how do we improve?	Metrics set before launch

Good vs mediocre products

Great products	Mediocre products
Solve one core problem exceptionally well.	Try to do everything and do nothing great.
Feel obvious: users do not need a tutorial.	Need onboarding, help documents and support calls.
Get better the more you use them.	Feel the same on day 1 and day 100.
Spread through word of mouth.	Need heavy marketing for each new user.
Earn trust: they are transparent about what they do.	Lose trust when rules and costs are unclear.

Six habits that build product sense

Product sense is a practice, not a talent. Build it on purpose:

Habit	What to do	Weekly target
1. Use products intentionally	Ask why each design decision was made, and what trade-off it reflects.	Pick one screen a day
2. Do product teardowns	Map the user journey of one product. Note what is brilliant and what is broken.	One product a week
3. Form and defend opinions	Say 'feature X is a mistake because…' and reason out loud.	Three written opinions
4. Read launches critically	Ask who the launch is for, and whether it is a real insight or only a feature.	Two launches a week
5. Talk to non-PM users	Have casual conversations, not formal interviews. Every person is a free focus group.	Two conversations a week
6. Write down your opinions	Keep a log so you can check later whether you were right.	One entry a day

NEW · COMMON PRODUCT THINKING TRAPS

Three traps and how to avoid them

Trap	What it sounds like	Ask instead
1. Solution-first thinking	'Let's build a chatbot!'	What problem are we solving?
2. Building for everyone	'This feature will help all our users.'	Which segment is this really for?
3. Building at the wrong time	'Online grocery will work, people always need groceries.'	Is the market ready for this solution right now?

The deck gives a timing example: one online grocery service failed in 2009, and a later one thrived in 2022. The deck attributes the first failure to market readiness. Treat timing as a question to test, not a fact to assume.

NEW · PROBLEM STATEMENTS

The problem statement formula

Before you define a solution, define the problem precisely. Use one formula every time:

[USER] NEEDS [OUTCOME] BECAUSE [INSIGHT]

Part	What to write	Example from the deck
User	A specific segment, not 'users'.	First-time home buyers aged 28 to 35 in metro cities
Outcome	What they need to achieve, not the feature to build.	...need to understand their loan eligibility quickly
Insight	The 'why now': evidence, behaviour or root cause.	...because the current process has seven confusing steps

A good statement can be tested. A poor one ('users want a better app') cannot. Write three statements for one product you use, then pick the one with the clearest evidence.

NEW · EXERCISES

Breakout exercise and take-home assignment

Breakout: Bistro by Blinkit (15 minutes)

Scenario: the app gets strong installs and good first orders, but users do not come back within five to seven days.

1. Who is the user? Be specific.
2. What are they trying to do? Describe the context.
3. Why are they not coming back? List two or three reasons, marked as hypotheses.
4. What is the biggest problem? Pick one.
5. Write a problem statement using the formula above.

Rule: do not jump to solutions too early. A good answer names a user and a problem before any feature.

Take-home: Nykaa journey

Explore the Nykaa app with a clear goal, such as buying a face mask, finding a lotion for dry skin, or browsing. Break your journey into steps (open the app, search, view a product, add to cart, check out). For each step, note what the user wants and whether it feels smooth, confusing, slow or frustrating. Name three specific experiences and form a clear view on each.

Then: speak to two people who do not work in product or design. Ask about their experience with the app, what they like and dislike, and why they may have stopped before buying. Reflect on what you usually ignore, whether your view changed after talking to users, and what was hardest.

SELF-CHECK

Did you name a specific user? Did you write the problem before any solution? Did you test your reasons with real people?

Quiz with answers

1. Name the three parts of a product in the handbook's definition.
   Answer: customer value (the job done), experience (how it feels) and business model (why it is sustainable).
2. What are the two halves of product management, in the deck's words?
   Answer: creating value for users and capturing value for the business.
3. List the five PM activities in the day-to-day routine.
   Answer: user input, problem clarity, team alignment, decision making, measurement.
4. Which question comes first in the product thinking framework: solution or problem?
   Answer: the problem space comes first.
5. Rewrite 'users want a faster app' using the problem statement formula.
   Answer: for example, 'Busy parents who cook on weeknights need to get dinner planned in minutes because they search three apps each night.' The user and the evidence must be specific.
6. What is the 'solution-first' trap?
   Answer: jumping to a feature before defining the problem.

MODULE 1 · FINAL

Completion checklist

Completion checklist

Done	Item
☐	Read the coverage map and marked the new topics
☐	Wrote a problem statement for one product
☐	Completed the Bistro breakout
☐	Completed the Nykaa journey and two user conversations
☐	Kept a product-sense log for one week
☐	Answered the quiz without notes